DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

How Does Hashem Run the World Through Malakhim?

Derech Hashem 2:5:3-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 5, paragraphs 3-5 (after a review of paragraphs 1-2) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 8 July 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are in the book

The Rabbi set the chapter in context. Derech Hashem has four parts: Part 1 is about Hashem, learned over the winter; Part 2 is hashgahah, how Hashem interacts with the world and with people; Part 3 is prophecy; Part 4 is practical misvot. Until now Part 2 has dealt with the laws of hashgahah: animals, the nations, Israel, the righteous and the wicked, the World to Come, gilgulim. Chapter 5 turns to the manner in which Hashem oversees, in two parts: His perception (hashkafah) and His influence (hashpaah).

On perception, last class established that when the Torah says Hashem "looked," it cannot mean He found something out, since He knows everything. It means He now acts on, or exercises, what He knows.

Paragraph 3: everything comes through a chain

How is Hashem involved in the world? Exactly in the order He desires. We learned earlier that all of existence comes into being through a chain (hishtalshelut); nothing exists directly from Hashem. Just as existence itself comes through the chain, so does its continued existence and anything that happens in it. His influence is never completely direct. He gives the energy to a malakh, who passes it to the one beneath him, level after level, until the lowest one actually brings about existence or change in the physical world.

The Rabbi paused on the word malakh. It means a messenger, one sent to do something. "Vayishlah Yaakov malakhim lefanav" is sometimes translated as angels, but Yaakov sent messengers. Angels are called malakhim because their role is to act as Hashem's messengers; "if I send you to do something for me, you're my malakh." He showed how in Hebrew a prefixed mem turns a verb into a noun, as moshav (a settlement) comes from yashav (to sit, to dwell).

The Ramhal adds a warning: do not think that because the influence passes from one malakh to the next, each has independent existence. The existence of every messenger is sustained entirely by Hashem; only the execution is delegated. The Rabbi's analogy was a CEO who pays

everyone's salary and decides who keeps his job, issues orders and oversees everything from the top, but is not involved in the day-to-day work. This, he said, is the whole concept of the ten Sefirot in Kabbalah: levels of emanation descending until they are rooted in physical reality.

Can a malakh misread the message?

A participant asked whether there is any room for interpretation as the message passes down. The Rabbi called it a beautiful question. Malakhim almost always do exactly what they are told, yet the Midrashim contain strange stories of malakhim apparently acting on their own, such as the view that the nefilim came from malakhim who took human wives. Another participant suggested that Hashem's instruction contains within it more detail than the lower levels can grasp, so each level receives it filtered to its own capacity. The Rabbi agreed: malakhim have no free will, but they can still make a mistake.

A participant then asked about the Haggadah: "I and not a malakh, I and not a saraf." The Rabbi agreed that the Exodus was an exception, a direct act by Hashem Himself. Such directness is normally too intense to bear, as at Sinai, where the people heard the voice, fainted, and asked Moshe to speak to them instead. He suggested that this is why the night of Pesah is like day, the only night we say Hallel: there is an illumination that allows a direct revelation, and it takes the forty-nine days of the Omer to work back up to that level.

Paragraph 4: each malakh sticks to its task

Hashem placed in every messenger the drive to do what it is told and to keep to it. It changes only when pushed aside within Hashem's precise system. The Ramhal's example: there is a sar over a tree, whose role is to keep that tree in existence. When Hashem decrees, the sar over the wind is strengthened, overrides the sar of the tree, and the tree is uprooted.

There are also malakhim of retribution (gemul), whose task is to carry out reward and punishment, and they can override the malakhim of nature. The Rabbi's illustration: suppose Hashem wants to punish a person walking by. The malakh of the tree is still doing its job of keeping the tree standing, but another malakh, whose role is that this person should die, overrides it, and the tree falls on him. Or the reverse: according to nature a person sheltering under a tree in a storm should be struck by lightning, but the malakh of gemul moves things so that he is saved.

Practical Kabbalah and its dangers

Within this paragraph, the Rabbi said, lies the whole concept of practical Kabbalah (Kabbalah maasit). The system is like the layers of an onion. Someone who understood all the levels and combinations could in theory manipulate them, "like a game," and send a particular malakh somewhere. But a human being has tunnel vision. You may solve one person's problem without seeing the ripple effects elsewhere. It is well known, he said, that people who played with these practices often had strange things happen to them or to their families.

A participant noted that Hashem can adjust the system because He is in charge of it and sees all of it, whereas someone tweaking from below is just moving a domino. And do we even have the right? "Even if you know, you don't have the right to touch it. Which is why we stay away from this." Even if such people could help you personally, "that's not the way you do things."

Paragraph 5: someone oversees it all

"Vehu yitbarakh shemo mashgiah al hakol." Despite this whole system, never forget that there is a CEO at the top. Hashem oversees the higher and lower worlds, roots and branches, with one constant aim: the perfection of creation. He decides whom to push away, whom to bring near, whom to purify, so that everything reaches its completion.

Coming next: miracles

Everything so far concerns natural events: a tree falling on someone is still nature, with one malakh overriding another. But what happens when the sea splits? A participant suggested that Hashem breaks the chain at that moment. The Rabbi said that is how the Ramhal will see it, whereas the Rambam will disagree completely: every miracle was built into the nature of things during the six days of creation. Another participant asked whether, if Hashem knows everything, He created contingencies in advance. "Excellent. That's going to be the point of contention." To be continued next week.

Summary

- Hashem's influence always passes through a chain of malakhim, level after level; it is never direct, except in rare cases such as the Exodus.
- A malakh is a messenger; it has no independent existence and no free will, though it can err.
- Paragraph 4: each malakh keeps to its task until overridden by Hashem's decree, including by malakhim of retribution.
- Practical Kabbalah tries to manipulate this system; the Rabbi warned to stay away, since no one can see the ripple effects and we have no right to interfere.
- Paragraph 5: above the whole system, Hashem directs everything towards the perfection of creation.

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